

dime. There are two compound-interest scenarios: a conservative (and likely) average return of 3 percent over the course of 48 years, and a healthier, more optimistic return of 6 percent over 48 years, from when you're 17 to 65 years old.

YOUR STASH-AWAY CASH at Age 17	YEARLY DEPOSIT for 48 Years	VALUE @ 65 (3% Return)	VALUE @ 65 (6% Return)
\$2,000	\$0	\$8,264.50	\$32,787.74

So by this chart, it would seem that a little pain and discipline at the age of 17 will reward you with anywhere between \$8,000 and \$32,000 later in life, *even if you invested absolutely nothing at all, ever again*.

But what if putting aside \$2,000 a year, which was hard at first and hardly noticeable later, became something you did as automatically as brushing your teeth? And you set aside \$2,000 a year, every year for 48 years, because it was something you'd been doing since you were a teenager?

Let's look at *those* numbers.

AGE	PRINCIPAL	YEARLY DEPOSIT for 48 years	VALUE @ 65 3% returns	VALUE @ 65 6% returns
17	\$2,000	\$2,000	\$223,345.80	\$576,706.54

In all those years, you've progressed from being an undisciplined teenager to being someone who could be worth half a million dollars. How? By understanding that as a young person, time works to your advantage, and by insisting that saving money is as crucial to your health. You buckled down and made a few sacrifices, which were big at first—you borrowed a prom dress instead of buying a new one; you didn't backpack through Europe with your friends; you didn't own a car during college. But eventually, setting aside \$2,000 a year felt as necessary as brushing your teeth. And soon it was completely painless. This saving strategy gives new meaning to a million-dollar smile.